

From Policy to Action: IFRC Supports Eswatini's New Disaster Risk Management Authority Through Anticipatory Action Initiatives



Figure 1: Launch of the National Disaster Risk Management Authority in the Kingdom of Eswatini

The Government of Eswatini has officially launched the National Disaster Risk Management Authority (NDRMA) on 28 April 2026 marking the transition from the former National Disaster Management Agency (NDMA) and a major shift in the country's approach to disasters. This move signals a deliberate departure from a predominantly response-oriented system towards a forward-looking, risk-informed and anticipatory framework. It reflects growing recognition that disasters are not isolated emergencies, but predictable and manageable risks that require sustained preparedness, early action, and long-term resilience building.

The NDRMA is established under the National Disaster Risk Management Act of 2025, which provides a strengthened legal and institutional basis for disaster risk governance in Eswatini. While the NDMA played a vital role in coordinating disaster response and recovery, escalating climate-related hazards, socio-economic vulnerabilities, and recurrent shocks highlighted the need for a more comprehensive mandate.

The revised Act expands the authority's responsibilities beyond emergency response to include disaster risk reduction, preparedness, anticipatory action, and resilience building. Launched by the Deputy Prime Minister Thulisile Dladla, the NDRMA represents a significant reform aimed at ensuring that disaster risk is addressed proactively and

systematically, in support of sustainable development and the protection of vulnerable communities.

This step positions Eswatini among a growing number of countries in Southern Africa demonstrating leadership in proactive disaster risk management.

A Risk Context That Demands Anticipation

Eswatini's disaster risk profile underscores the urgency and importance of this transition. The country is exposed to a range of hydrometeorological hazards, including recurrent droughts, flooding, severe storms and strong winds. These hazards intersect with structural vulnerabilities, including reliance on rain-fed agriculture, pockets of poverty, and exposure of informal settlements. As a result, disasters in Eswatini often have disproportionate impacts on women, children, rural communities, and people depending on subsistence livelihoods.

Historically, responses to these shocks have been largely reactive, mobilizing resources after impacts have already occurred. While lifesaving, such approaches are costly and insufficient in the face of increasingly predictable climate hazards. The launch of the NDRMA represents a strategic shift to act earlier, smarter, and based on risk and the Deputy Prime Minister Dladla emphasized at the launch that *"The authority must strengthen early warning systems so that timely and reliable information reaches all communities, including rural and vulnerable populations. It must ensure that disaster risk reduction is integrated into development planning, so that public investments are protected and future risks are reduced"*.

From Management to Risk Governance

The evolution from the NDMA to the NDRMA reflects a deeper transformation in how disaster risk is understood and governed. Under the previous framework, disaster management was primarily centered on coordination of response, often triggered once impacts were already visible, but the National Disaster Risk Management Act broadens this scope by elevating disaster risk reduction and preparedness as core national priorities, embedding anticipatory action, enabling early responses based on forecasts, triggers, and risk analysis, promoting multi-sectoral coordination, linking climate, water, agriculture, health, social protection, and infrastructure planning and supporting resilience building at community, institutional, and systems levels.

By institutionalizing these functions within the NDRMA, Eswatini is creating the legal and operational space to invest before crises escalate, reducing humanitarian needs and safeguarding development gains.

Creating an Enabling Environment for Anticipatory Action

The launch of the NDRMA is particularly significant in the context of anticipatory action. This new authority provides a stronger foundation for linking early warning systems with early action protocols, scaling forecast-based financing and pre-agreed response mechanisms, strengthening collaboration between national institutions, traditional structures, civil society, and international partners and bridging humanitarian action, disaster risk reduction, and climate adaptation.

In a country where droughts and floods are increasingly predictable, anticipatory action has the potential to protect lives, livelihoods, and public resources, while reinforcing national ownership of disaster risk decisions.

Translating Policy into Early Action

The IFRC commends Eswatini for this forward-looking reform and looks forward to seeing how the NDRMA advances anticipatory action, reduces disaster losses, and strengthens resilience for all EmaSwati.

The establishment of the NDRMA creates significant opportunities for Baphalali Eswatini Red Cross Society, supported by the International Federation of Red Cross and Red Crescent Societies (IFRC), to further advance anticipatory action in Eswatini. With an active Drought Early Action Protocol, a Flood simplified Early Action Protocol under development, its strong community presence, volunteer network, and experience in early action, livelihoods support, and disaster preparedness, Baphalali is well positioned to support the operationalization of anticipatory action at local level linking national early warning systems to community-based early action, targeting the most vulnerable households before shocks escalate. Through IFRC's global expertise in forecast-based financing, early action protocols, and risk-informed programming, the Red Cross (Baphalali Eswatini Red Cross Society, IFRC, British Red Cross Society and Red Cross Red Crescent Climate Centre are already supporting the NDRMA in scaling anticipatory action mechanisms, strengthening risk analysis, developing pre-agreed triggers, and promoting coordination across sectors. This partnership offers a pathway to translate policy into practice, ensuring that anticipatory action delivers timely, people-centered and locally led protection of lives and livelihoods in the face of recurrent climate hazards.

A Commendable Step Forward

The launch of the National Disaster Risk Management Authority is more than an institutional rebranding, it is a signal of intent, the Deputy Prime Minister Dladla explained that *"This transition is not only symbolic. It represents a significant change in the way Government intends to manage disaster risk. The country is moving from a system that was largely associated with disaster response to a stronger and more proactive system focused on risk reduction, preparedness, early warning, response, and recovery"*. It reflects political commitment to protecting people not only when disasters occur, but before they unfold.

As climate risks intensify across Southern Africa, Eswatini's proactive stance offers an encouraging example of how countries can move beyond response, embrace anticipation, and invest in resilience as a development priority. Continued success will depend on sustained resourcing, strong coordination, community engagement, and the effective operationalization of anticipatory and preparedness mechanisms but the foundation is now firmly in place.

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